

Running OUT OF STEAM

They were young and invincible, out to conquer the world. They are just a little older now and a whole lot more defeated.



| By Sharda Ugra |

During Australia's injury-ridden tour of India, a member of their support staff chose a *desi* ring-tone for his mobile. Or maybe it was just a distant, sardonic message to Mahendra Singh Dhoni & Co. What rang from the Aussie's number particularly after the 4-2 win in Guwahati, was *Jai Ho*.

India can hardly sing at all these days. They lost a home ODI series to an Aussie team in a uniform covered with gold, green and band-aid. That is not merely a bad result. It is a warning notice stuck on a public wall.

Last season, around this time, the Indians were creaming the competition. The world T20 champions had won ODI series in Australia and Sri Lanka. Dhoni's squad had shed the old boys and been injected with India's bursting youthful talent. Duly retitled "Youngistan" by a cola sponsor, new India was rich with fearlessness and praise be to all gods, fielding ability. At least, that's what we believed.

» UPHILL STRUGGLE

Some players in the squad have yet to come to terms with the game's demands

Today, after a stinging ODI series defeat, there are no bubbly drinks going around in the Indian dressing room and the flavour of its Gen Next these days is largely flat. It may seem petty to pick only on the young, when an older, more experienced batting order also failed to beat the Aussies.

Yet given that once India's young Turks were Yuvraj Singh, Virender Sehwag, Harbhajan Singh and M.S. Dhoni, it is fair to ask whether the new rookies are ready to step up, now that they have stepped in.

After India's heady CB Series win in Australia, every man certainly seemed to announce at the top of his lungs that he was. Out of the 10 young players who featured in the event, only Gautam Gambhir has made that

rewarding stride—in all forms of cricket. Nine could not follow him.

Rohit Sharma, Robin Uthappa, R.P. Singh, Sreesanth, Manoj Tiwary, Irfan Pathan, Piyush Chawla remain on the fringe of ODIs, even as Sreesanth has just been selected for the Sri Lanka Test series. Far from being the new fast bowling revelation who opened up Ricky Ponting like a can of beans, Ishant Sharma has dropped in pace and sting. Munaf Patel and Praveen Kumar are in the mix but so is their bowling.

The most prominent of the young generation is left-handed batsman Suresh Raina who until the seventh ODI versus Australia had played 85 ODIs. Yet, he has not been able to become the leader of the Turks or be considered a

SURESH RAINA

The left-hander, once called the greatest talent of his generation, has played more than 80 ODIs but has yet to make a mark overall and win a big game on his own